opportunity to portray themselves as champions of their people, extracting favorable outcomes from allegedly unyielding international elites.

IOs have two main levers for appeasing populists: increasing the benefits of membership and decreasing its costs. These tactics leverage the fundamental logic of international cooperation, wherein states weigh the costs and benefits of participation when deciding whether to engage with multilateral institutions (Keohane 1984).

To increase the benefits provided, IOs might offer populists greater formal or informal influence, such as key appointments, larger voting shares, or the ability to shape agendas. Financial incentives like increased lending or technical assistance are another powerful draw. Prestige also plays a role; populists may gain symbolic victories by hosting IO events, delivering speeches in high-profile forums, or receiving favorable classifications.

To reduce costs, IOs might lower the barriers to membership by waiving dues, overlooking rule violations, or turning a blind eye to controversial policies. For instance, dispute-settlement bodies might decline to rule against a populist state, or human-rights institutions might ignore transgressions to avoid conflict (Busch and Pelc 2010; Voeten 2021). Narrowing the scope of obligations by demanding less of members in general has also proven effective in placating resistance.

Importantly, appeasement need not mean major concessions. IOs often adopt symbolic or low-cost measures to address populist grievances without undermining the IOs' core missions. Selective appeasement can involve giving populists just enough to quiet dissent while preserving institutional integrity. For instance, IOs might promise reforms but delay implementation, gambling that a populist leader will leave office before the changes take effect. NATO's symbolic increases in member contributions to appease Donald Trump during his first term—without granting him deeper concessions—exemplify this approach.

Some IOs also use appeasement tactically, providing incremental benefits over time rather than all at once. This creates leverage: If populists continue to escalate their attacks, IOs can withhold further incentives, mitigating the risk of outright extortion. Changes to vote shares in international financial institutions often follow such a pattern (Carnegie and Clark 2023).